



Intro to CER

CER is...

Claim
Evidence
Reasoning

This is the framework good writers use to write clear and logical arguments



$$C \rightarrow E \rightarrow R$$

CLAIM

What are you arguing?

EVIDENCE

What in the text supports your argument?

REASONING

How does the evidence prove your argument?

A strong response needs all three.



CLAIM

Your claim is your answer to a question.

A strong claim:

- Answers the question / Makes a specific point / supported with evidence

Question: How does the author show that the main character is afraid?

- Weak: The character is afraid.
- Stronger: The author shows that the character is afraid through her nervous actions and hesitant dialogue.

Your claim tells your reader what you are going to prove.



A Simple Claim Formula

Answer the question + make a specific point

Question: How does the setting affect the character?

Claim: The isolated setting causes the character to become increasingly suspicious and fearful.

You don't have to start with I think... frankly, you shouldn't. In literary analysis, state your argument confidently. There is no I in literary analysis (except the two that there are). You are focusing on the topic at hand, and you're not involved in it. Stick to the page and the text.



EVIDENCE

Evidence is the proof for your claim.

Your evidence can be:

- A quotation / A specific action / A detail from the text / Dialogue / Description / An event

Don't just drop a quote into your paragraph.

- The character is afraid. “She looked around the room.”
- The character's fear is shown when she “looked around the room,” suggesting that she feels threatened even though no danger is immediately visible.



Not All Evidence Is Equal

Ask yourself: Does this evidence actually prove my claim?

If your claim is: The character is becoming isolated from everyone around her.

Poor evidence= she eats breakfast.

Better evidence = She stops talking to her friends and begins avoiding them.

Best evidence = A specific moment that shows her actively withdrawing from people.

Choose evidence that gives you something to ANALYZE.



This is really the most important part.

REASONING

Reasoning explains: HOW does this evidence prove my claim? AND WHY does it matter?

Evidence: The character stops talking to her friends.

Weak reasoning: This shows she is isolated.

Stronger reasoning: By choosing to withdraw from the people closest to her, the character creates distance between herself and her support system. This shows that her fear is beginning to affect her relationships, not just her emotions.



REASONING = THE "SO WHAT?"

After you give evidence, ask: SO WHAT? Why does this detail matter?

What does it reveal about:

- Character? Conflict? Theme? Setting? Author's purpose?
Symbolism? Tone? Society?

Example: Evidence: The character refuses to leave the house. So what? → She is afraid. So what? → Her fear has become powerful enough to control her actions. So what? → The author may be showing how fear can limit a person's freedom.

That's analysis.



Claim answers the WHAT.
Evidence tells us WHERE.
Reasoning tells us WHY it proves the
WHAT.

C+E+R

CLAIM: The author shows that fear can control a person's choices.



EVIDENCE:

The character refuses to leave the house even when her friends encourage her to go outside.



REASONING:

Her decision shows that her fear has become stronger than her desire to interact with others. Rather than simply feeling afraid, she allows that fear to determine what she does. This demonstrates how fear can limit a person's freedom and choices.



CER PRACTICE

Worksheet + Activity

